Troy SD K-5 ELA

The Quantitative Case for Curriculum Change

Pressure-testing Collaborative Literacy + UFLI Foundations

Executive Summary — Citations + Appendix

Prepared May 2026 • 50-district national benchmark • 2009-2025 coverage

Repo: github.com/akarpo/tsd-k5ela-choice   Live: tsd-k5ela-choice.karpowitsch.org

The question — and the one-line answer

Three independent pieces of evidence converge on the same answer

QUESTION

Is Collaborative Literacy 3rd Ed. + UFLI Foundations the right K-5 ELA choice for Troy's balanced-literacy → Science of Reading transition?

ANSWER

No.

The evidence converges from three independent directions:

0 of 50

outperformer + peer districts[1] use Collaborative Literacy as their K-5 core.

There is no national precedent for the combination Troy is considering.

19 of 20

Education Scorecard 2026[3] ELA-relevant outperformer districts run, supplement, or are transitioning to SoR-aligned curricula.

Demographic-adjusted gain methodology — Harvard, Stanford, Dartmouth.

Only Wayne County NC stayed in pure balanced literacy.

3 of 3

of Troy's stronger alternatives have named district adoptions with recovery evidence.

Amplify CKLA – Marion Co KY[30], Fond du Lac WI[33]
EL Education – Detroit DPSCD[42]
Wit & Wisdom – W. Baton Rouge[37], Baltimore

First, the honest pre-COVID picture — Troy gained on aggregate, but subgroups were uneven

SEDA cohort-standardized scale (cs): NAEP-anchored grade-level units. +1.0 = one grade above national norm.

Why this matters

Any argument for change has to start by acknowledging what's true: pre-COVID, Troy was healthy on the only metric that compares across state tests fairly[1–2]. Calkins UoS didn't break Troy historically. Pretending otherwise undermines the credibility of the post-COVID case (which IS strong).

Troy SD 2009 → 2019 on SEDA cs scale[2]

```
•  All Students:      +0.486 → +0.747   (+0.26)
•  Asian:             +0.712 → +1.063   (+0.35)
•  White:             +0.450 → +0.609   (+0.16)
•  Black:             -0.070 → -0.160   (-0.09)
•  Hispanic*:         +0.340 → +0.033   (-0.31)
•  Econ Disadv:       -0.210 → +0.078   (+0.29)
•  Not-Econ Disadv:   +0.552 → +0.853   (+0.30)

* Hispanic suppressed pre-2011 (N<10); baseline is 2011.
```

Aggregate gains went to Asian, White, Not-ECD, and EconDis subgroups. Black + Hispanic subgroups stagnated or slipped slightly — the pre-COVID story was uneven.

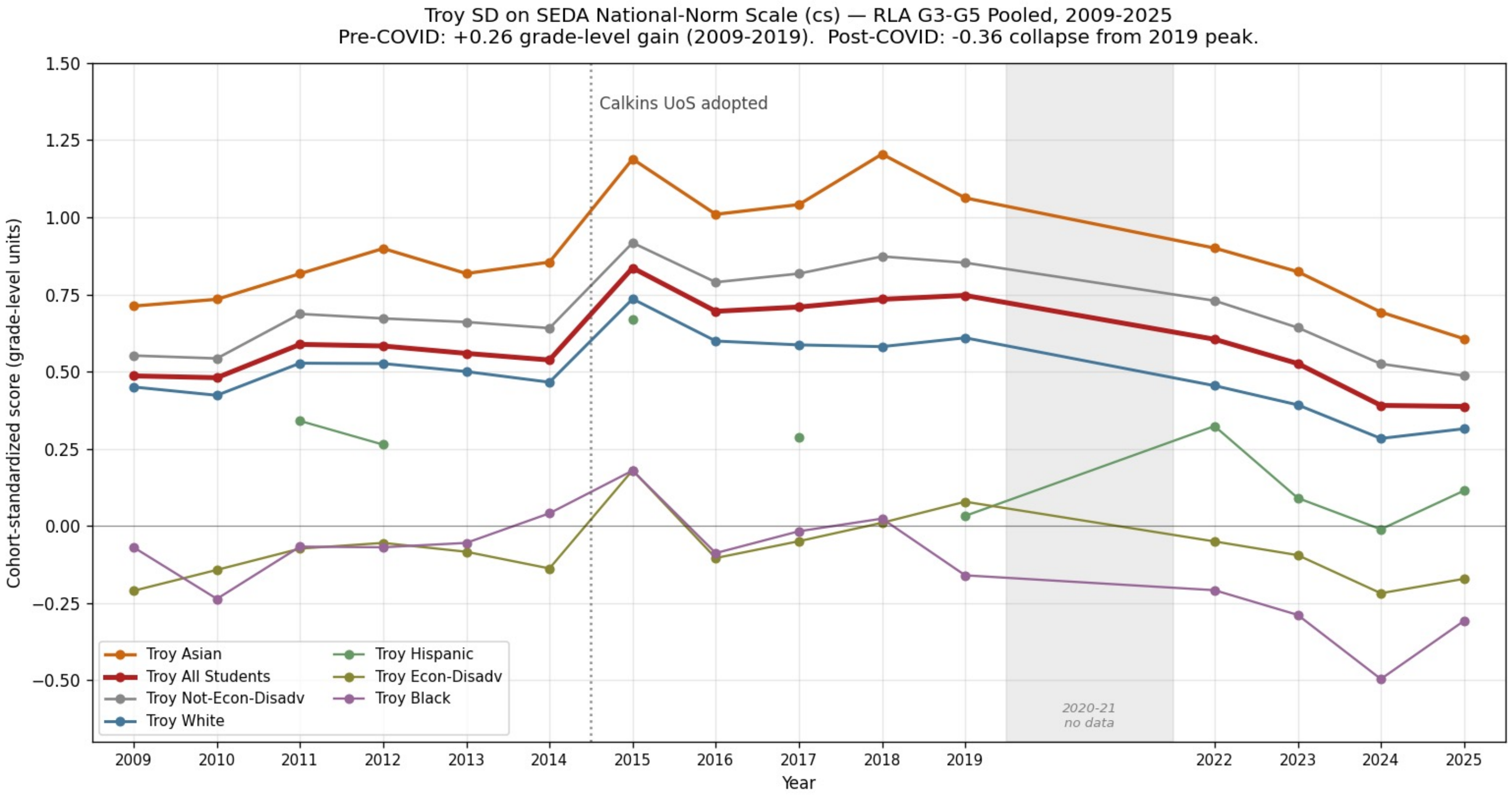
What this rules out

- "Calkins UoS has been failing Troy for a decade."
  Mostly false. Aggregate + affluent gains 2009-2019.
  (Caveat: Black + Hispanic subgroups stagnated.)
- "This is a long-running trend that COVID exposed."
  False. 2019 was Troy's peak on the aggregate scale.
- "Troy was on a declining trajectory."
  False. Troy outperformed every MI affluent peer on aggregate 2009-2019.

The case for change is NOT retrospective.
The collapse is post-COVID (2019→2025) — and it hit every subgroup.

The post-COVID collapse is the real signal

Troy's 2019 peak was +0.747. By 2025: +0.387. Lost 16 years of slow gains in 3 years.



From 2019 peak to 2025[1]

All Students	-0.36
Asian	-0.46
White	-0.29
Not-ECD	-0.37
EconDis	-0.25
Black	-0.15
Hispanic	+0.08 †

(grade-level units)
† small-N subgroup (~3-4% of Troy)

Four straight years of decline

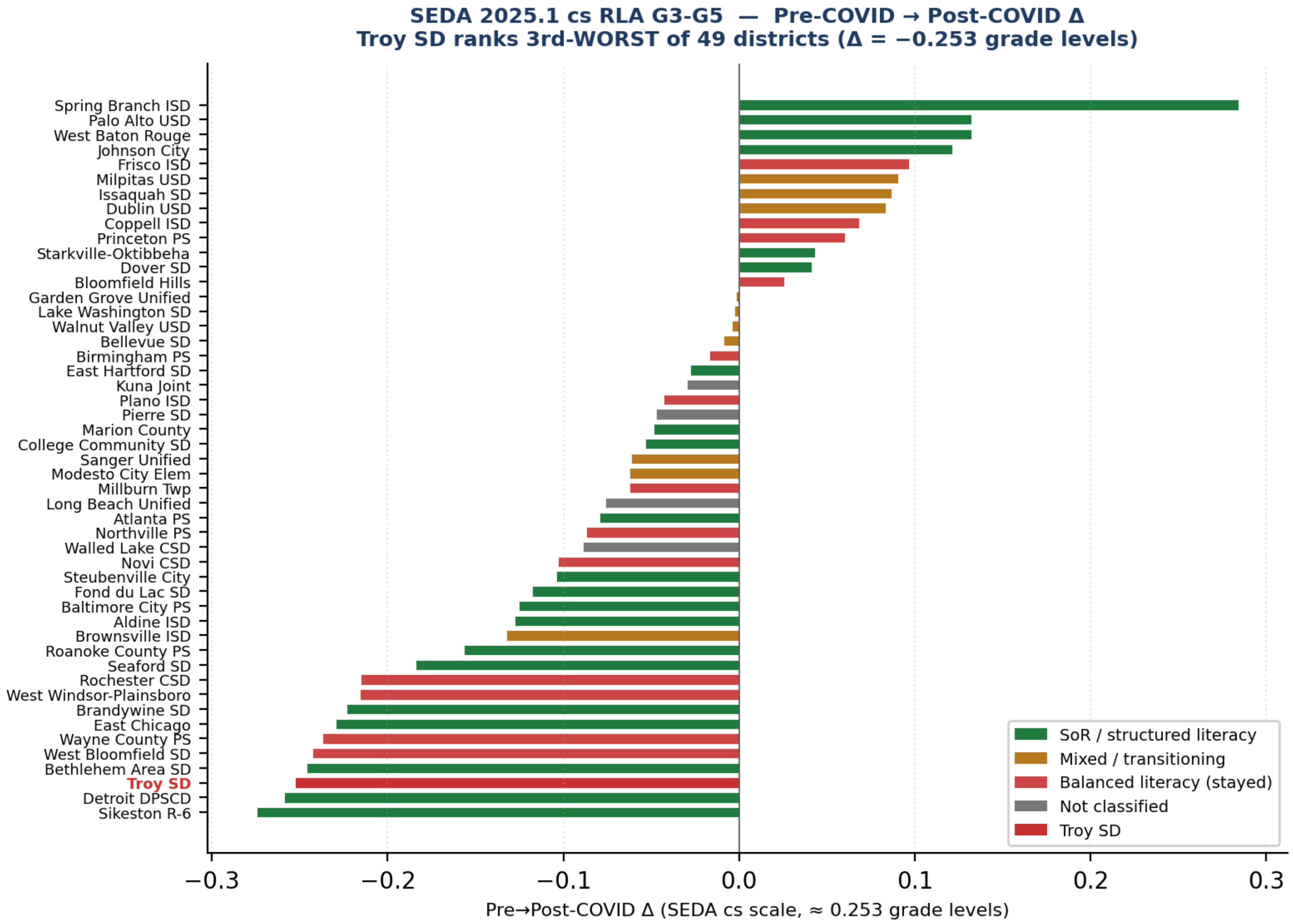
2022: +0.605
2023: +0.526
2024: +0.390
2025: +0.387

The 2025 Troy score (+0.387) is BELOW Troy's 2009 score (+0.486).

Sixteen years of slow gains erased in three years — and recovery has not started.

Of 50 demographically-comparable + outperformer districts, Troy ranks 47 of 49

Pre-COVID (2017-19 mean) vs Post-COVID (2022-25 mean) on SEDA cohort-standardized RLA scale



Bottom 5 districts (Δ pre→post)

48	Sikeston R-6	−0.275	
47	Detroit DPSCD	−0.259	
46	Troy SD	−0.253	◄
45	Bethlehem Area SD	−0.246	
44	West Bloomfield	−0.243	

Top 5 districts (Δ pre→post)

1	Spring Branch ISD	+0.284	(TX STR[36])
2	Palo Alto USD	+0.132	(ESRI[35])
3	West Baton Rouge	+0.132	(W&W[37])
4	Johnson City TN	+0.121	(TN HQIM[39])
5	Frisco ISD	+0.097	(BL)

Pattern

Districts that GAINED post-COVID all run structured-literacy cores.

Districts at the bottom either (a) face severe poverty headwinds (Sikeston, Detroit) or (b) are affluent BL districts (Troy, West Bloomfield).

The comprehensive view — every district, every curriculum type

Curriculum alone doesn't determine recovery. But magnitude of gain correlates with structured literacy.

Of 49 districts with sufficient pre/post-COVID data[1]:

13 gained on the SEDA scale • 36 declined • Many SoR-adopters also declined — recovery is not automatic.

Big gain (Δ ≥ +0.10)

4 districts — ALL SoR

Spring Branch ISD	+0.284	TX STR[36]
Palo Alto USD	+0.132	ESRI[35]
West Baton Rouge	+0.132	W&W[37]
Johnson City TN	+0.121	TN HQIM[39]

100% of districts in this tier run structured-literacy programs.

Next-strongest gainer outside this tier: Frisco ISD (TX, BL) at +0.097.

Moderate gain (+0.05 to +0.10)

6 districts — mixed

Frisco ISD	+0.097	BL
Milpitas USD	+0.090	Benchmark
Issaquah SD	+0.087	Benchmark '24
Dublin USD	+0.084	Bench+Heggerty
Coppell ISD	+0.068	BL
Princeton PS	+0.060	BL (NJ peer)

Mix of BL, Benchmark-Advance, and recently-adopted structured literacy.

Flat or declined (Δ < +0.05)

39 districts — both types

Detroit DPSCD	−0.259	EL Ed (SoR)
Aldine ISD	−0.034	CKLA (SoR)
Baltimore PS	−0.213	W&W (SoR)
Fond du Lac	−0.014	CKLA (SoR)
Seaford SD	−0.180	Bookworms (SoR)
Troy SD	−0.253	Calkins UoS (BL)

36 of 49 had Δ < 0; 3 held flat (Bloomfield Hills, Starkville, Dover). SoR alone is necessary but not sufficient — recovery also needs sustained PD, universal screeners, and a 2-3-year cohort lag (slide 19).

Honest finding: SoR doesn't guarantee recovery. But the only districts achieving STRONG recovery so far are SoR-aligned.

A second independent benchmark — Education Scorecard 2026 'Districts on the Rise'

Demographic-adjusted gain methodology (Harvard-Stanford-Dartmouth[3]) — catches outperformers SEDA raw Δ misses

What DOTR measures (different from SEDA raw Δ):

Demographic-adjusted gain ≥ 0.3 grade levels in BOTH 2019–2025 AND 2022–2025, with ≥4 demographically-comparable peer districts in-state. Detroit DPSCD is a DOTR outperformer despite a SEDA raw Δ decline — it gained more than its demographics predicted.

Math + Reading outperformers (17)

East Hartford CT	Fundations + Heggerty + Fund. Unl.	**SoR**
East Chicago IN	Heggerty + Reading Horizons + coaches	**SoR**
Marion County KY	Amplify CKLA + LETRS	**SoR**
Baltimore City MD	Wit & Wisdom K-8 (2018-)	**SoR**
Detroit DPSCD MI	EL Education K-5 (2018-)	**SoR**
Starkville MS	MS HQIM (BL→structured shift)	**SoR**
Pierre SD	Open Court + OG + Heggerty + Barton	**SoR**
Johnson City TN	TN HQIM (SoR mandate)	**SoR**
Spring Branch TX	TX STR framework	**SoR**
Fond du Lac WI	Amplify CKLA + DDI + UVA-PLE	**SoR**
Dover NH	Knowledge-building shift	**SoR-lean**
Brandywine DE	Explicit phonics K-2	**SoR-lean**
Sikeston R-6 MO	Teacher-developed + state LETRS	**SoR-lean**
Atlanta APS GA	Benchmark + HMH (Phase 2 SoR)	**SoR-trans.**
Kuna Joint ID	HMH Into Reading planned 2026-27	**SoR-future**
College Comm. IA	MTSS focus (curriculum unclear)	**Unclear**
Wayne County PS NC	Stayed BL	**BL**

Reading-Only outperformers (3)

Modesto City Elem CA
Benchmark Adv + UFLI + LETRS
→ SoR-patched

West Baton Rouge LA
Wit & Wisdom + Wilson Fundations
→ SoR

Roanoke County VA
W&W + Heggerty + Really Great Rdg
→ SoR

Summary across both groups

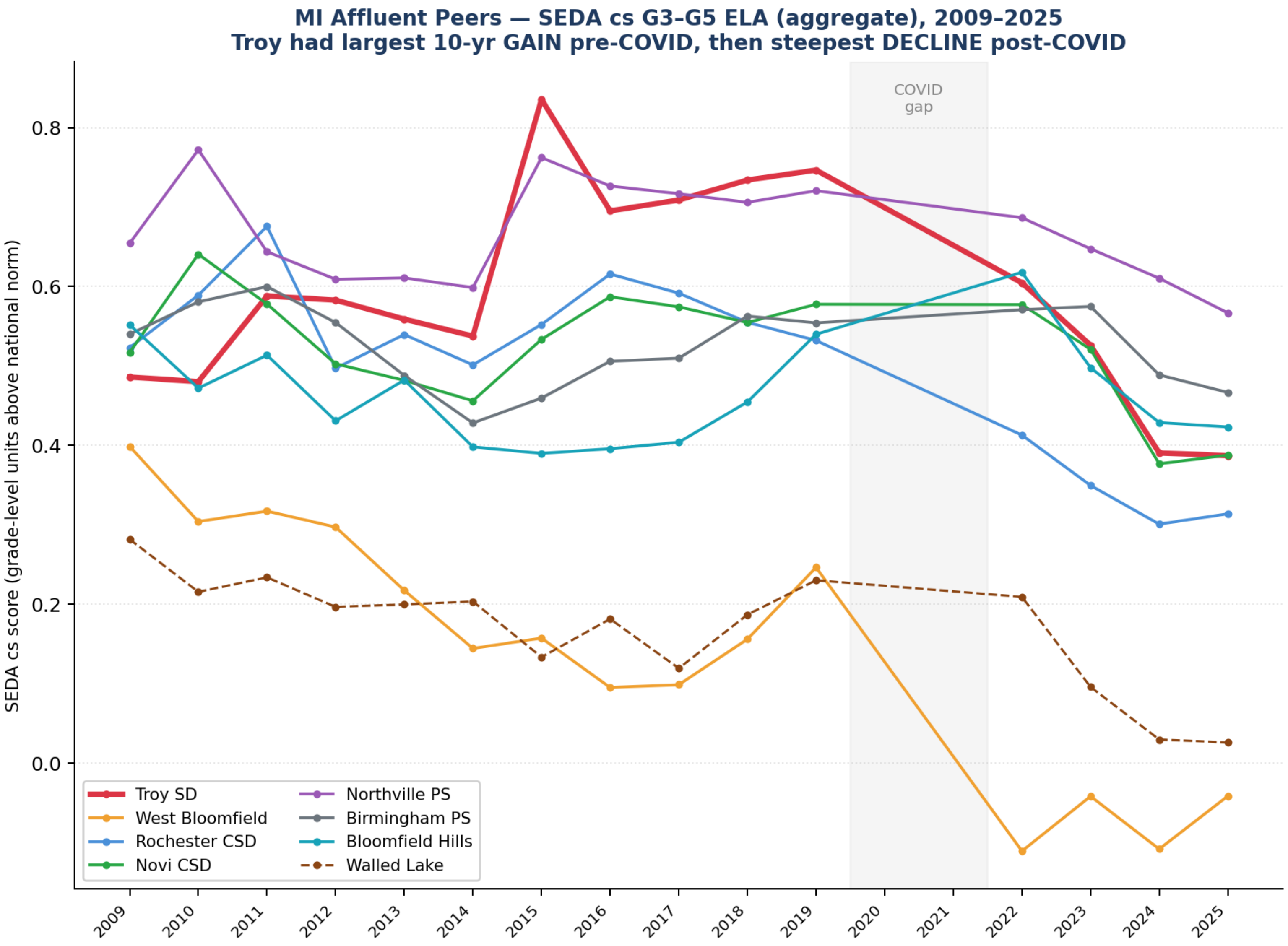
- 13 districts: clear SoR-aligned core
- 5 districts: SoR-leaning / patched / transitioning
- 1 district: future SoR adoption
- 1 district: unclear curriculum
- 1 district: stayed BL (Wayne County NC)

19 of 20 = 95% SoR-aligned

Two independent methodologies converge: SEDA raw Δ + Education Scorecard demographic-adjusted gain both point at structured literacy.

Of 8 Michigan affluent peers, Troy fell the furthest

Same state, same M-STEP test, similar demographics. Pre-COVID expected vs post-COVID actual (SEDA cs Δ).



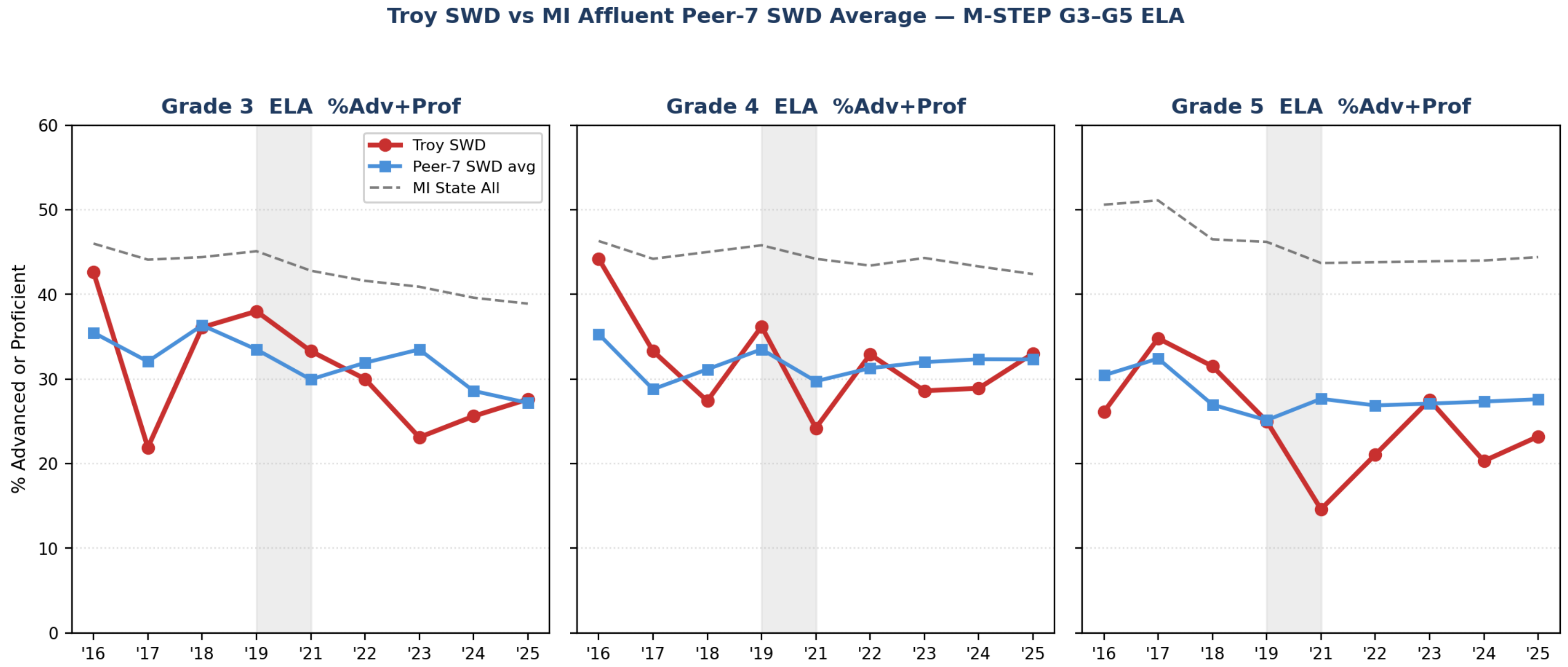
Pre→Post COVID Δ (expected pre-COVID in parens)

District	All	Asian	White	Black
Troy SD	-0.25 (0.73)	-0.35 (1.10)	-0.23 (0.59)	-0.27 (-0.05)
West Bloomfield	-0.24 (0.17)	+0.07 (0.43)	-0.12 (0.38)	-0.27 (-0.28)
Rochester CSD	-0.21 (0.56)	-0.17 (0.76)	-0.23 (0.57)	-0.34 (0.07)
Novi CSD	-0.10 (0.57)	-0.03 (0.73)	-0.23 (0.59)	-0.34 (-0.08)
Northville PS	-0.09 (0.71)	-0.28 (1.17)	-0.08 (0.65)	–
Birmingham PS	-0.02 (0.54)	-0.10 (0.93)	-0.02 (0.59)	-0.06 (0.07)
Bloomfield Hills	+0.03 (0.47)	-0.02 (0.78)	+0.08 (0.46)	-0.45 (0.00)

District	Hisp	EconDis	Not-ECD
Troy SD	-0.03 (0.16)	-0.15 (0.01)	-0.25 (0.85)
West Bloomfield	-0.21 (-0.09)	-0.25 (-0.28)	-0.20 (0.41)
Rochester CSD	-0.11 (0.23)	-0.16 (-0.08)	-0.21 (0.64)
Novi CSD	+0.16 (0.16)	-0.24 (-0.07)	-0.05 (0.62)
Northville PS	+0.23 (0.29)	+0.02 (-0.04)	-0.08 (0.76)
Birmingham PS	-0.08 (0.58)	+0.03 (-0.02)	-0.01 (0.59)
Bloomfield Hills	–	+0.01 (-0.21)	+0.04 (0.54)

The Students-with-Disabilities subgroup tells the same story — only louder

MI School Data M-STEP %Adv+Prof[10] (different metric from SEDA cs scale — direct MDE source for Troy SWD)



Pre→Post-COVID Δ (M-STEP %Adv+Prof)

Grade	Troy	Peer-7	Gap
Grade 3	**-11.6 pp**	-3.8 pp	**-7.9 pp**
Grade 4	-1.6 pp	-0.1 pp	-1.5 pp
Grade 5	**-4.6 pp**	+0.7 pp	**-5.3 pp**

G3: Troy SWD fell 3× faster than peers.
G5: Peers gained; Troy fell.

Why this matters

- Troy SWD G3: 37% pre-COVID → 25% today.
  Peer-7 SWD G3: 35% → 31% (held much better).
- Pre-COVID Troy SWD ≈ Peer-7 SWD.
  Post-COVID Troy SWD sits 4–7pp BELOW peers.
- SoR is engineered for struggling readers.
  The students who benefit MOST from SoR
  are falling FASTEST at Troy vs. same-state peers.
- Refutes "regression-to-mean" — SWD students
  aren't high-achievers regressing.

Two independent sources converge: SEDA cs scale (49 districts) and MDE M-STEP %prof (Troy subgroups) both say the SoR-relevant subgroups are falling fastest.

The subgroup data refutes the three common defenses

Each common defense of Troy's current trajectory is testable on the SEDA scale[1]. Each fails the test.

1

"It's the ESL/ELL composition."

If true: Hispanic and EL subgroups should be hit hardest.

Data: Troy Hispanic Δ = −0.031. Rank 12 of 39 — best of Troy's subgroups[1].

REFUTED. The Hispanic subgroup is the most resilient at Troy.

2

"It's the disadvantaged students."

If true: EconDis subgroup should be hit harder than Not-ECD.

Data: Troy EconDis Δ = −0.147 (rank 32/47). Troy Not-ECD Δ = −0.252 (rank 42/46)[1].

REFUTED. Not-ECD declined MORE than EconDis.

3

"It's a demographic / COVID story."

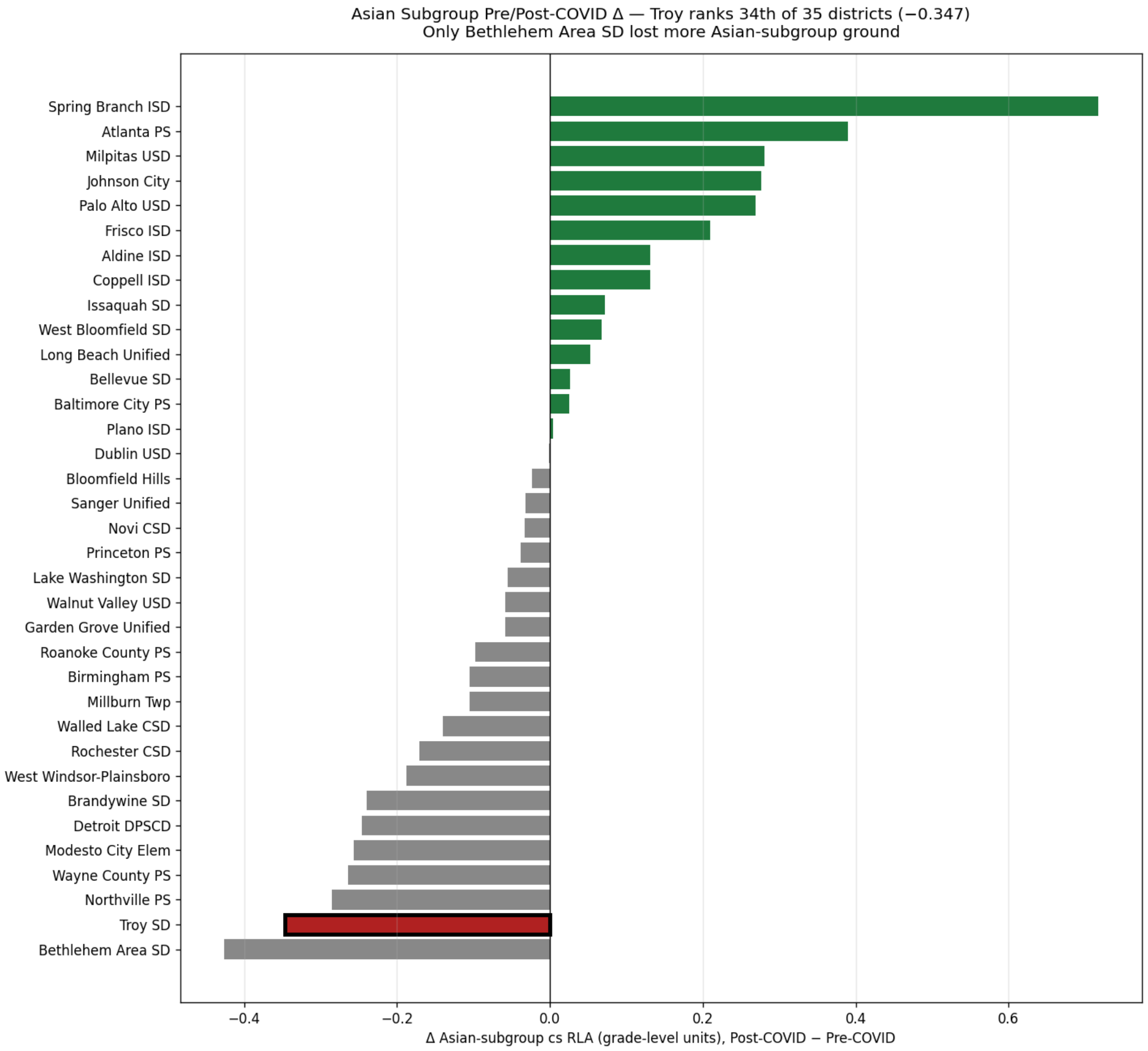
If true: Affluent students with home-literacy environments should be PROTECTED.

Data: Troy Asian Δ = −0.347 (34/35), White Δ = −0.231 (44/46) — the affluent subgroups dropped MOST[1].

REFUTED. Affluence provides no protection at Troy. This points at instruction.

Asian subgroup: Troy ranks 34 of 35 districts on post-COVID Δ

Of 35 districts with Asian-subgroup data in SEDA 2025.1, only Bethlehem Area SD lost more ground.



Asian subgroup top 5 (gainers)

```
Spring Branch ISD    +0.717  (TX STR³⁶)
Atlanta APS          +0.390  (SoR PD)
Milpitas USD         +0.281
Johnson City TN      +0.277
Palo Alto USD        +0.269  (ESRI³⁵)
```

Asian subgroup bottom 5

```
Bethlehem Area SD    -0.426
Troy SD              -0.347  ◄
Northville PS        -0.285
Wayne County PS      -0.264
Modesto City Elem    -0.257
```

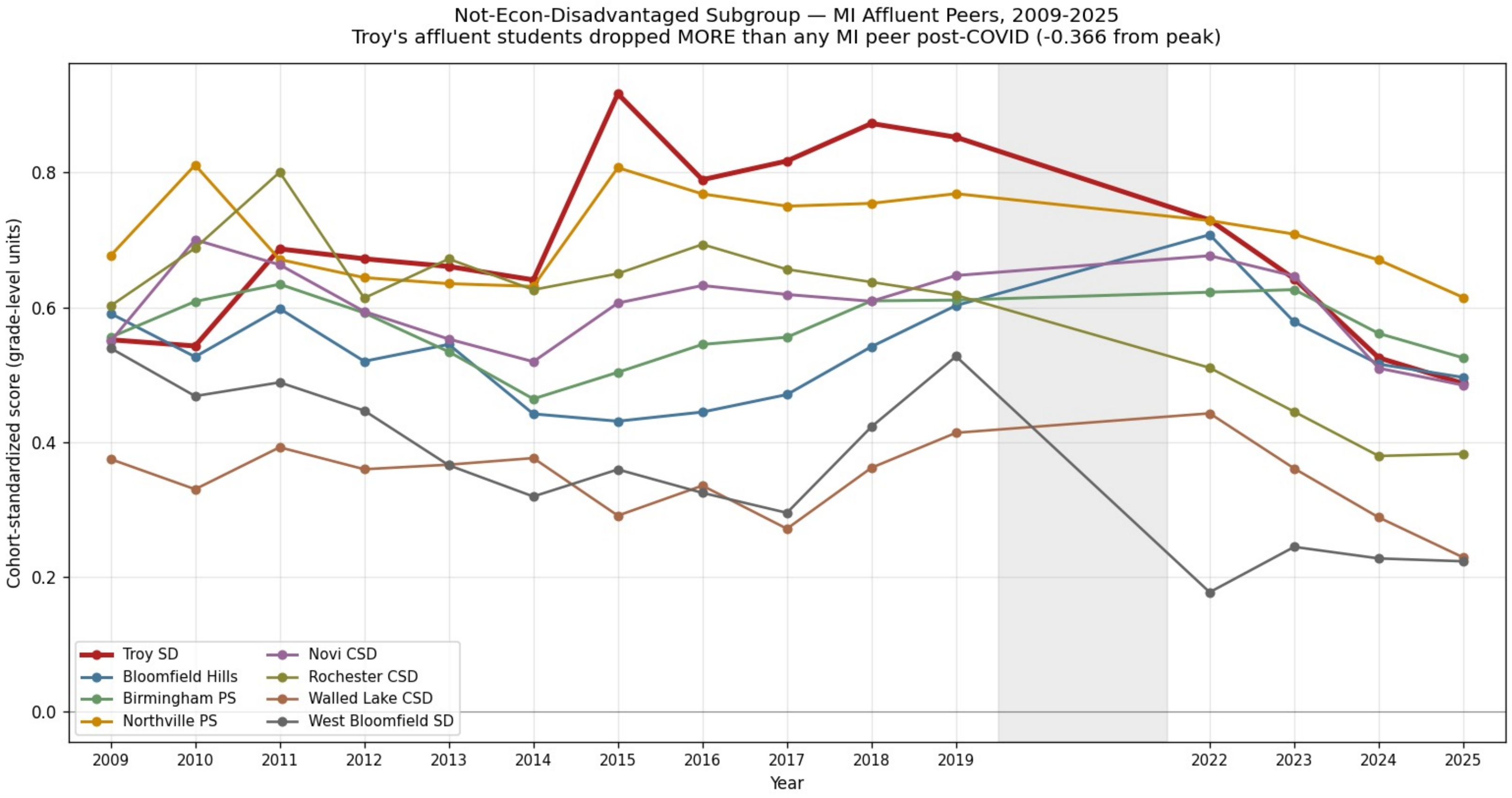
Direct affluent-peer signal

Palo Alto (Troy's closest demographic match by Asian %) exited Calkins UoS in 2021 via ESRI[35].

Result: +0.269 grade-level gain on Asian subgroup. Direct evidence the shift works.

Not-Econ-Disadvantaged subgroup: Troy ranks 42 of 46

Troy's affluent students dropped −0.252 grade levels post-COVID — more than 90% of districts in our universe.



Not-ECD top 5 (recovery)

```
West Baton Rouge    +0.315
Spring Branch       +0.193
Palo Alto USD       +0.138
Frisco ISD          +0.133
Issaquah SD         +0.124
```

Not-ECD bottom 5

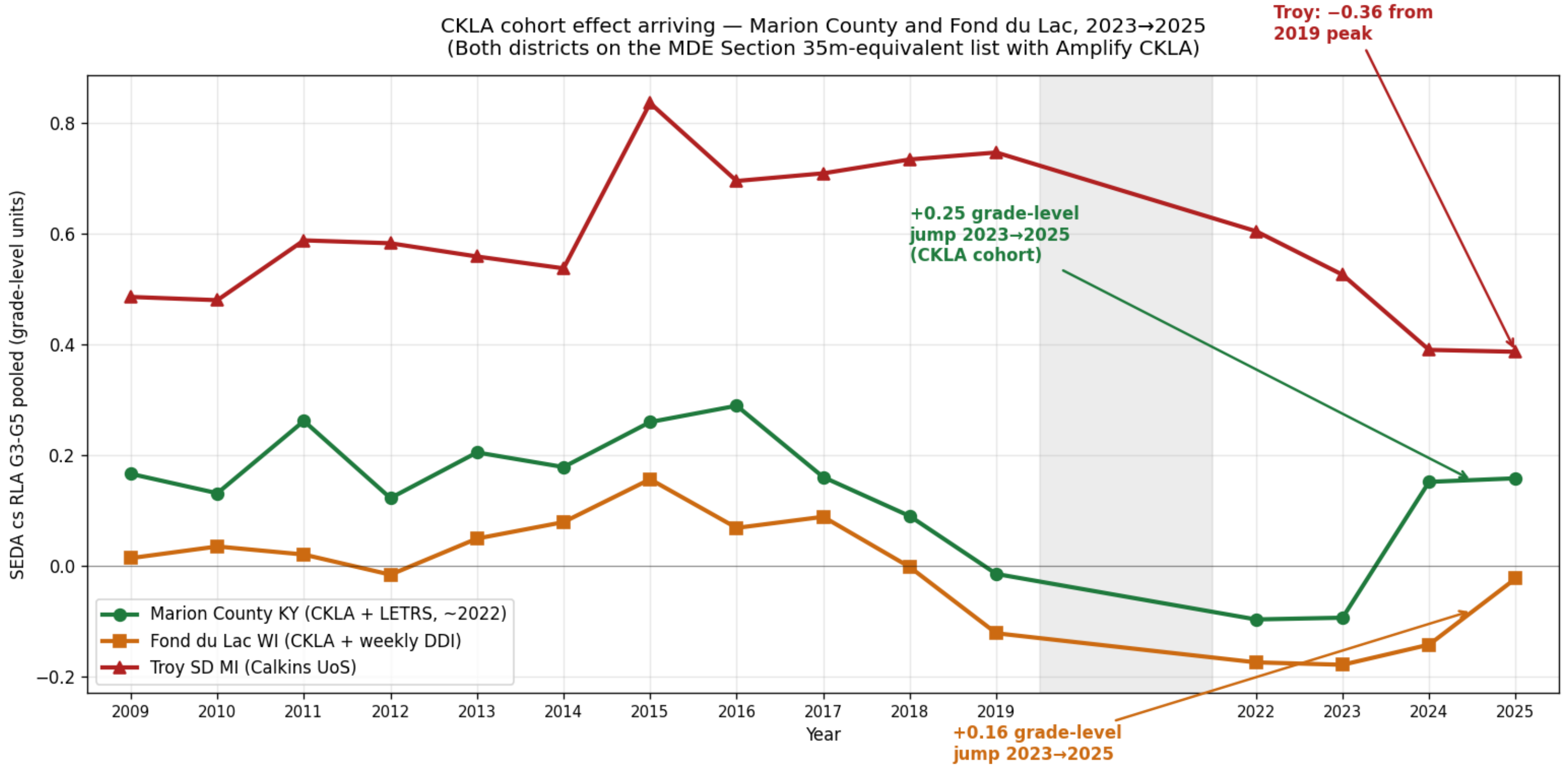
```
Bethlehem Area      -0.326
Wayne County PS     -0.302
Seaford SD          -0.301
Brandywine SD       -0.267
Troy SD             -0.252  ◄
```

Why this matters

These are the families with the most home-literacy resources. If Troy's curriculum design were sound, these are the kids who should recover first. They're recovering last.

CKLA-adopting districts on the MDE-approved list are leapfrogging their states

Marion County KY and Fond du Lac WI both adopted Amplify CKLA. Both gained vs their state averages while Troy lost ground.



State-relative gain after CKLA[1]

```
Marion County KY:
  Pre-CKLA vs state    +0.02
  Post-CKLA vs state   +0.19
  Δ vs state           +0.17

Fond du Lac WI:
  Pre-CKLA vs state    −0.02
  Post-CKLA vs state   +0.10
  Δ vs state           +0.12
```

Troy on the same scale

```
Troy SD MI (Calkins UoS):
  Pre-COVID vs state   +0.79
  2025 vs state        +0.67
  Δ vs state           −0.11

Troy is losing ~0.11 grade levels relative
to MI state.
The two CKLA peers gained +0.12 and +0.17
relative to their states.
```

How they did it — Marion County KY and Fond du Lac WI playbooks

Both districts adopted Amplify CKLA (Tier-1 on the MI MDE Section 35m approved list[18])

Marion County KY — Chris Brady, Supt.[30,32]

~2,937 students • 61% econ-disadvantaged • 83% White, 11% Hispanic

Curriculum stack

Amplify CKLA K-5 + Amplify ELA 6-8 (single-vendor vertical alignment). District-wide rollout in 2022-23, aligned with KY Read to Succeed Act of 2022.

Teacher PD

LETRS Volumes 1 & 2 via Kentucky Reading Academies[31] (state-paid, no cost to district) — 44 teachers AND administrators trained since 2022. Principals went through LETRS WITH teachers so they can evaluate foundational instruction in the same vocabulary.

Coaching restructure

Coaches moved from building-based to content-driven, operating in 6-9 WEEK CYCLES with teachers on standards-aligned instruction and diagnostic data. The single most unusual structural choice — most rural KY districts kept building-based coaching.

Implementation

Full district-wide rollout, NOT a pilot. Tech use reduced to reclaim student-teacher engagement time. G3-7 ELA proficient +10pp 2021-22 → 2024-25.

Result on SEDA scale

Pre-CKLA: −0.01 vs KY state. 2024-25: +0.19 vs state. +0.17 grade-level state-relative gain in 3 years. Marion County MS jumped 221→57 in KY state rank.

Fond du Lac WI — Matt Steinbarth, Supt.[33,34]

~6,457 students • 49.5% econ-disadvantaged • 59% White, 21% Hispanic, 9% Black

Curriculum stack

Amplify CKLA K-5 + Amplify ELA 6-8 + Bridges Math + TCI Social Studies + Mystery Science (K-8 coherent stack). Adoption aligned with August 2022 Strategic Plan.

Leadership development partnership

Partnered with the UVA Darden Partnership for Leaders in Education (UVA-PLE)[34]. Single biggest differentiator: CKLA embedded in a multi-year leadership and instructional-redesign program, NOT adopted as a standalone literacy textbook.

Teacher PD

Weekly Data-Driven Instruction (DDI) cycles trained via UVA-PLE. ~$20M ESSER funds deployed for curriculum + after-school + classroom libraries + AVID. WI Act 20 (2023) added a state legal forcing function[38].

Result

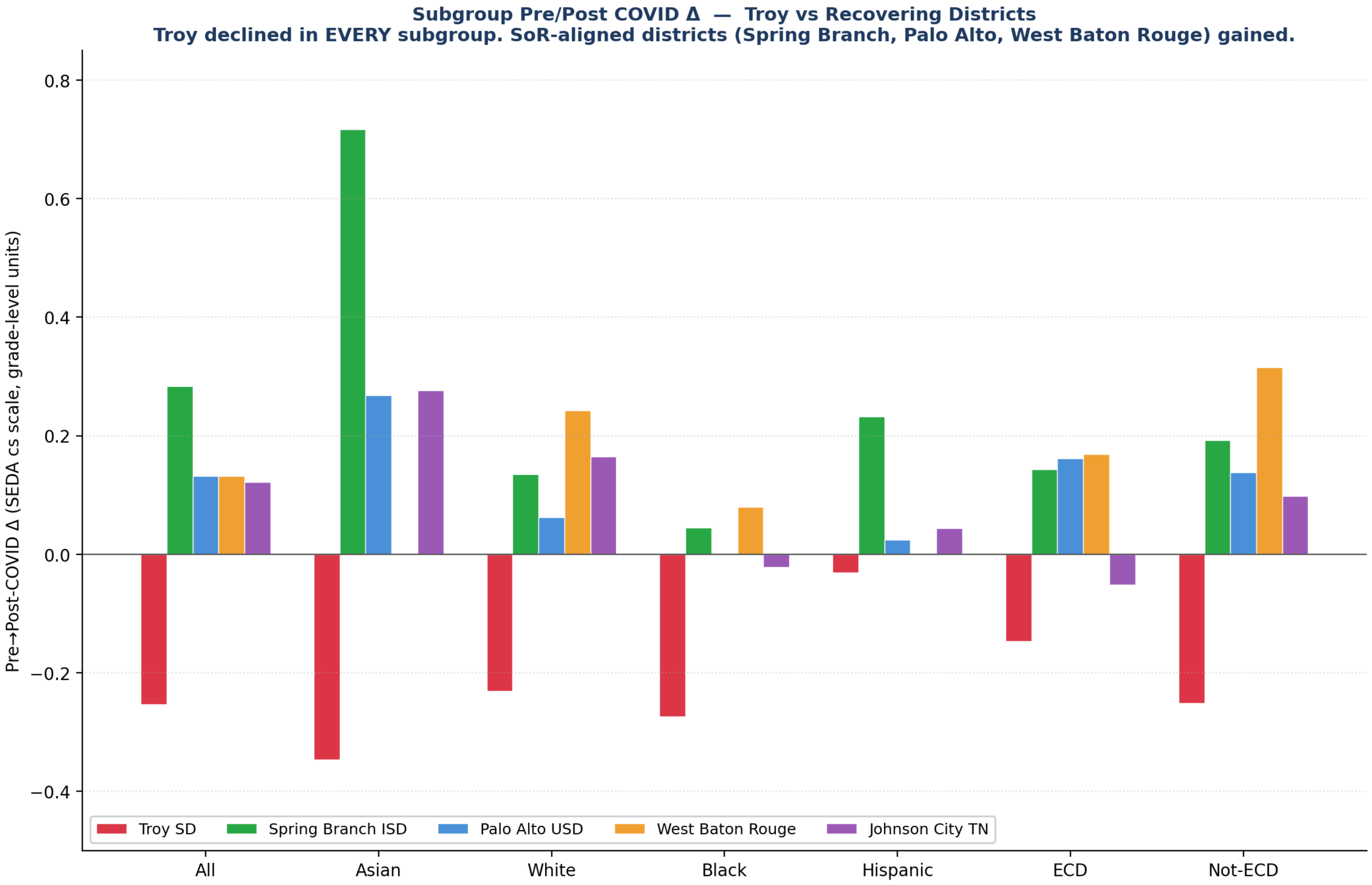
Jumped from 375th to 175th of 421 WI districts. "Exceeds Expectations" on 2024-25 WI report card — first time since 2016-17. Highest reading growth of all 421 WI districts 2022-2024.

Leadership transition

Supt Fleig led the redesign 2022-2025; retired May 2025. Board promoted CAO Matt Steinbarth (25-yr district insider) 7-0 to protect continuity. Credit the turnaround to Fleig + Steinbarth + UVA-PLE.

Recovery is possible — and it tracks with curriculum choice

Four districts gained post-COVID. All four run structured-literacy programs.



Spring Branch ISD (TX)[36]

+0.284 overall / +0.717 Asian / +0.193 Not-ECD

TX STR-aligned framework, K paraprofessionals trained in evidence-based instruction.

Palo Alto USD (CA)[35]

+0.132 overall / +0.269 Asian / +0.138 Not-ECD

Exited Calkins Units of Study in 2021 via Every Student Reads Initiative. Direct Troy parallel.

West Baton Rouge (LA)[37]

+0.132 overall / +0.315 Not-ECD / +0.242 White / +0.079 Black

Wit & Wisdom + Wilson Fundations K-3. K-3 literacy 57% → 68% in single year.

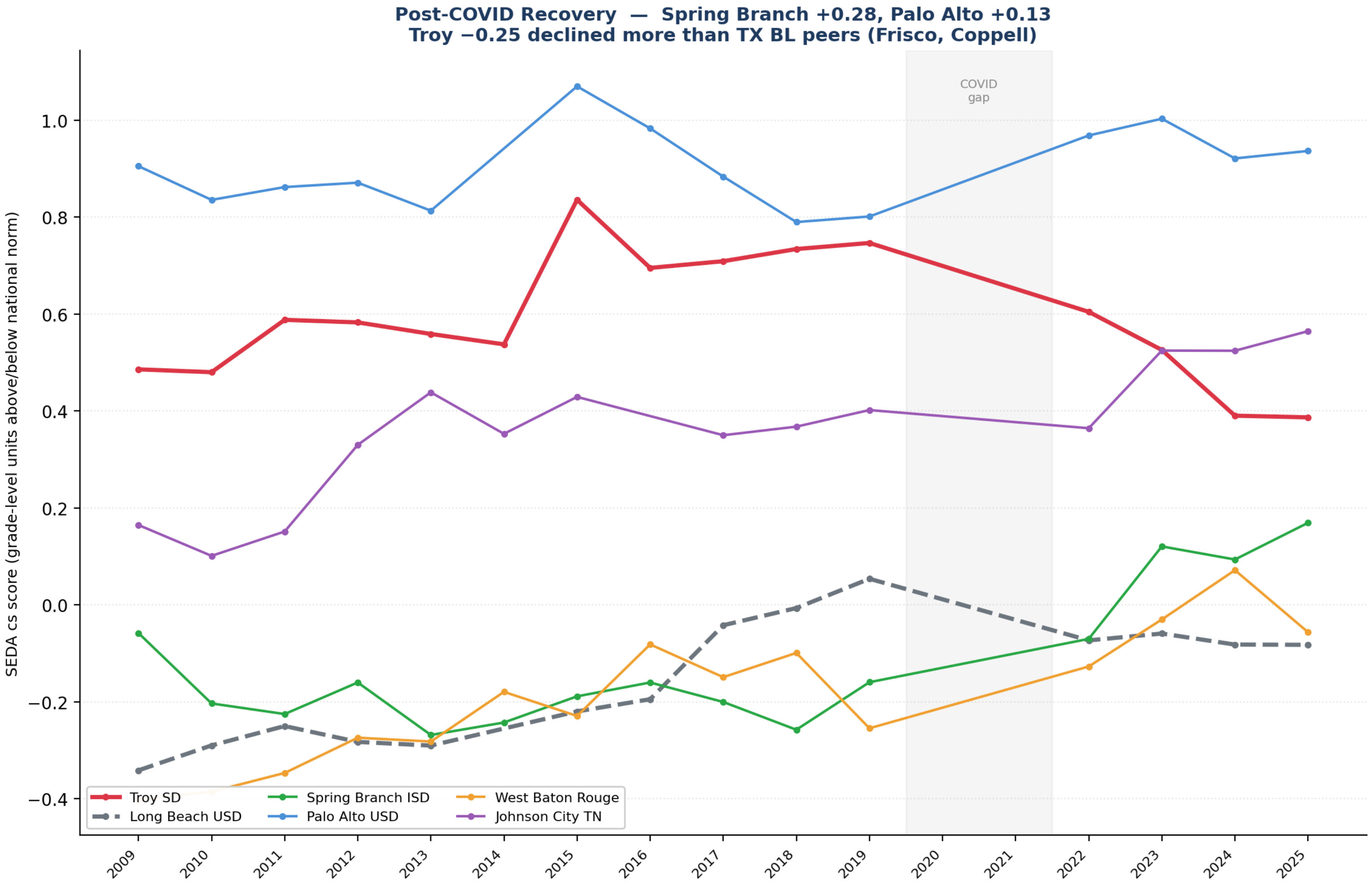
Johnson City TN[39]

+0.121 overall / +0.277 Asian / +0.165 White

Tennessee HQIM SoR mandate. +22pp above TN state on G4 ELA in 2025.

Long Beach USD — the natural experiment is now empirically visible

Same district, same Carl Cohn-era leadership culture, same demographics. Only the curriculum changed.



Long Beach trajectory

1992-2002 (Cohn era): Open Court basal
→ Broad Prize 2003

2010s drift: Teachers College Units of Study (Calkins)
→ same program Troy adopted 2014

Pre/Post-COVID Δ: −0.076 grade levels

Why this matters for Troy

Long Beach is the closest thing to a controlled trial against Calkins UoS in U.S. K-5 ELA data.

Same district. Same insider supt tradition. Same demographics. The pre-COVID period worked.

Post-COVID, the Calkins-derived core failed to support recovery — same pattern as Troy.

Why balanced literacy fails when school and home reading routines both break down

A plain-English causal story that's consistent with every subgroup finding

How Calkins UoS works[20,23]

- Workshop-model, student-led discovery
- Leveled-text independent reading
- Comprehension strategies (predict, infer, etc.)
- Minimal explicit phonics in core
- Relies on rich home language environment to fill gaps in explicit instruction
- Reading-aloud, book access, parent-supported reading time

What COVID broke[21]

- Classroom delivery — interrupted
- Home reading routines — disrupted
- Book access at home — limited
- Parent time for reading — fragmented
- Balanced literacy assumed BOTH school AND home would teach reading — when home routines broke down, school's part alone wasn't designed to do the whole job
- Most-affluent students had the MOST home reading support to lose, so they fell furthest

Why SoR districts recovered[22,25]

- Explicit phonics scope and sequence
- Decodable texts at K-2
- Knowledge-building core that doesn't assume background knowledge
- Cohesive sequence — same content in every classroom
- Doesn't depend on home support — designed to teach reading in school
- When classroom delivery returned, the curriculum was still intact and could rebuild skills

Tested hypothesis — does SoR help only early grades, not later ones?

If the 'BL for later grades' hypothesis were correct, BL districts should hold up at G5. They don't.

The hypothesis

"Maybe SoR helps for K-2 phonics, but balanced literacy still has a role at G3-G5 where comprehension + rich text matter more." — pedagogically plausible. Testable on this data.

Mean SEDA Δ by grade × curriculum type

Type	G3 Δ	G4 Δ	G5 Δ	n
SoR-clear	−0.088	−0.117	−0.065	21
SoR-recent/lean	+0.031	−0.011	−0.036	5
Mixed/Benchmark	+0.113	+0.133	+0.062	3
Balanced lit.	−0.102	−0.107	−0.083	15

Reading:
- BL districts decline at EVERY grade — they don't hold up better at G5. They decline less, but still decline.
- SoR-clear shows its SMALLEST decline at G5, not G3.
- SoR-recent adopters (Bellevue, Issaquah, Lake Wash., Modesto, College Comm.) actually GAINED at G3 (+0.031) — cohort effect from new-K students reaching G3 in '24-25.

Top 5 G5 gainers — 100% SoR-aligned

1	Spring Branch ISD	+0.284	TX STR
2	Johnson City TN	+0.221	TN HQIM
3	West Baton Rouge	+0.207	W&W + Fundations
4	Steubenville City	+0.176	Success for All (25 yr)
5	Starkville-Oktibbeha	+0.126	MS HQIM

Top 5 G3 gainers (for comparison):

1	Palo Alto USD	+0.205	SoR (ESRI)
2	West Baton Rouge	+0.142	SoR
3	Milpitas USD	+0.099	Mixed/Benchmark
4	Issaquah SD	+0.087	SoR-recent
5	College Community	+0.075	SoR-recent

The strongest G5 gainers are EXCLUSIVELY SoR.
The strongest G3 gainers are 4/5 SoR + 1 mixed.

Confounders this data can't resolve: Cohort effects (G5 had K 5 yrs ago); cross-grade scale differences; COVID hit early grades hardest (K-1 missed foundational year); small SoR-recent/Mixed n.

Curriculum verdict — Troy's options on the MI Section 35m list

Ranked by evidence strength + alignment with recovery patterns

#	Curriculum	EdReports	Recovery proof points	Comp.	Grade
1	Amplify CKLA 3rd Ed.	All Green[14]	Aldine[41] G4+11pp; Fond du Lac #1 WI[33]	Single	A+
2	EL Education K-5	All Green[14]	Detroit DPSCD[42]; NYC Reads Dist 11[43]	Single	A
3	Wit & Wisdom + Fundations + Geodes	All Green[14]	West Baton Rouge[37]; Baltimore W&W since 2018	2-3 vendor	A
4	UFLI Foundations (component)	Not reviewed[14]	RRQ 2025 ES >1.0 SD[24]	Supplement	A
5	Really Great Reading	196/198[14]	NYC Reads foundational core[43]	Supplement	A–
…	(…)				
11	**Collaborative Literacy 3rd Ed. + UFLI**	**2016 ed.: Partial[14]**	**Zero of 50 outperformers use it[1]**	**2-vendor**	**B / B–**
12	HMH Into Reading 2025	All Green (v1.0)[14]	Contested by APM Reports[21]	Single	B–

Collab Lit + UFLI is the weakest comprehensive option on the Section 35m list for a district moving OUT of balanced literacy.

Of 50 districts in the post-COVID national benchmark, zero use Collaborative Literacy as their K-5 core.
Of the 4 districts that GAINED on the SEDA scale 2017-19 → 2022-25, all four use structured literacy.
Of Troy's stronger alternatives — CKLA, EL Education, Wit & Wisdom — each has direct post-COVID recovery evidence.

Recommendation — three paths ranked

Each leg of the evidence base points the same direction

RECOMMENDED PRIMARY PATH

Amplify CKLA 3rd Edition K-5

Single vendor, integrated foundations + knowledge. All-green EdReports (first ELA program to earn it).
Marion County KY[30]: +10pp G3-7 ELA 2021-25 with CKLA + LETRS. Fond du Lac WI[33]: #1 reading growth statewide.

STRONG ALTERNATIVE — BEST OF BREED

Wit & Wisdom + Wilson Fundations K-3 + Geodes

West Baton Rouge LA[37]: K-3 literacy 57%→68% in ONE year. Best Not-ECD recovery (+0.315) in our universe.
Roanoke County VA[3]: closest demographic peer to Troy. Baltimore City: longest urban track record (since 2018).

HONORABLE MENTION

EL Education K-5 (+ phonics supplement)

Direct in-state Michigan validator: Detroit DPSCD[42] adopted 2018, outpaced state.
NYC Reads natural experiment[43]: District 11 (EL Education) outperformed both Into Reading and Wit & Wisdom.

IF TEACHER BUY-IN OR LOCAL POLITICS BLOCKS A CLEAN CHANGE

The least-bad fallback

Keep Collab Lit as a transitional core; drop Making Meaning in G3-5; substitute a knowledge-building supplement.
Use SIPPS for Tier-2 only and UFLI as Tier-1 K-2 phonics (avoid duplication). Commit to a 2-3 year sunset review.

Curriculum is necessary but not sufficient — and what to track

Five execution factors + the real-time peer benchmarks

Five execution factors in every winning district

1 ### Stack, don't bolt

Knowledge core + systematic phonics + teacher PD as ONE system

2 ### 60+ hours structured PD

LETRS most-cited[31] (3 of 20 DOTRs); brand varies; depth doesn't

3 ### Universal screeners + MTSS

MDE-approved K-3 screeners: mCLASS/DIBELS 8, Amira, MAP Reading Fluency

4 ### Plan for a 2-3 year lag

Bethlehem K-change 2015 → G3 bounce 2018[26]

5 ### Fidelity is the binding constraint

NYC Phase 1 conf 55% vs Phase 2 38%[43] = real outcome gap

Track these districts in real time

Lake Washington WA

Board adoption Spring 2026

→ Closest demographic peer mid-shift

Bellevue SD WA

Year 2 of ARC Core + UFLI + Heggerty

→ Year-2 SBA fall 2026

Issaquah SD WA

First post-Benchmark Advance SBA

→ Fall 2026

Palo Alto USD CA

Year 5 post-ESRI CAASPP trend

→ Annual CAASPP

Fond du Lac WI

Continued CKLA + DDI trajectory

→ WI Forward fall 2026

Aldine ISD TX

Watch G5+G6 STAAR 2026 (full post-CKLA cohort)

→ TEA TAPR fall 2026

Appendix — Methodology

Datasets, metrics, time windows, district universe

Primary metric

SEDA cohort-standardized score (cs): NAEP-anchored grade-level units. 0.0 = at-grade national norm; +1.0 = one grade above national norm.

This is the only metric that is genuinely cross-state comparable in absolute terms — it normalizes M-STEP, CAASPP, STAAR, LEAP, MAAP, TCAP, NJSLA, SBA, OST against a common NAEP-anchored scale.

Time windows

```
Pre-COVID baseline:  2017-2019 (3-year mean)
Post-COVID window:  2022-2025 (4-year mean)
Δ = post − pre (units: grade levels)

2020 and 2021 omitted from SEDA — state tests were canceled or
partially administered nationwide. This is the SEDA team's
standard recovery-window convention.
```

Grade pooling

G3-G5 ELA only. Pooled within district × year, weighted by tested-student count per grade. Math excluded (this analysis is about ELA).

District universe — 50 targeted, 49 with valid SEDA Δ

- Troy SD + 7 MI affluent peers (8)
  (Bloomfield Hills, Birmingham, Northville, Novi, Rochester, Walled Lake, West Bloomfield)
- 4 CA workbook peers + 4 CA outperformers (8)
  (Palo Alto, Milpitas, Walnut Valley, Dublin + Modesto, Sanger, Garden Grove, Long Beach)
- 6 TX districts (6)
  (Aldine, Brownsville, Coppell, Plano, Frisco, Spring Branch)
- 3 NJ peers + 3 WA SoR-shift peers (6)
  (WW-Plainsboro, Millburn, Princeton + Bellevue, Issaquah, Lake Washington)
- Steubenville (OH gold standard) + Detroit DPSCD (MI in-state) (2)
- 15 additional Education Scorecard 2026 DOTR districts (15)
  (CT, DE, GA, IA, ID, IN, KY, MD, MO, MS, NC, NH, SD, TN, WI — Detroit + Spring Branch already counted)
- 2 DOTR Reading-Only adds (2) (West Baton Rouge LA, Roanoke County VA — Modesto already in CA)
- 3 sustained / early-SoR comparators (3) (Seaford DE, Valley Stream 30 NY, Bethlehem PA)

Counts referenced elsewhere in the deck:

20 = ELA-relevant DOTR districts (17 Math+Reading + 3 Reading-only). 28 = predecessor state-test analysis (raw % proficient on M-STEP/CAASPP/STAAR/etc., before SEDA expansion) — see reports/quantitative_analysis.md.

References (1 of 5) — Primary datasets

Each cited claim in the deck is anchored to one of these sources

1 **Stanford Education Data Archive 2025.1**
Reardon, S. F., et al. (2026). SEDA v2025.1. https://edopportunity.org/trends/data/downloads/ • Coverage 2009-2025; cohort-standardized scale anchored to NAEP.

2 **SEDA 6.0 (geographic district file)**
Reardon, S. F., et al. (2026). SEDA v6.0. https://edopportunity.org/opportunity/data/downloads/ • Coverage 2009-2019; used to validate pre-COVID baseline.

3 **Education Scorecard 2026 "Districts on the Rise"**
Harvard / Stanford / Dartmouth. https://educationscorecard.org/districts-on-the-rise/ • 17 demographically-adjusted post-COVID outperformer districts.

4 **Troy achievement workbook (8 districts)**
tsd-achievement.karpowitsch.org master workbook • G3-G7 × subgroup × year, 2019-2025, 5,497 demographic cells.

5 **CAASPP Smarter Balanced Research Files**
https://caaspp-elpac.ets.org/caaspp/ResearchFileListSB • CA district-level ELA, 2019-2025; used for Modesto, Sanger, Garden Grove, Long Beach.

6 **Texas TAPR / TEA**
https://rptsvr1.tea.texas.gov/perfreport/tapr/ • STAAR reading G3-G5 for Aldine, Brownsville, Spring Branch, Plano, Frisco, Coppell.

7 **Louisiana DOE LEAP**
https://doe.louisiana.gov/students/assessments/ • West Baton Rouge Parish 2022-2025 LEAP Mastery+.

8 **Mississippi DOE MAAP**
https://reports.mdek12.org/ • Starkville-Oktibbeha 2019-2025 (via tpcref.org compilation).

9 **Tennessee Department of Education TCAP**
https://www.tn.gov/education/ • Johnson City Schools 2019-2025 district assessment files.

10 **Michigan School Data CEPI / M-STEP**
https://www.mischooldata.org/ • Troy SD trajectory + statewide G3-G5 averages.

11 **Ohio Department of Education / OST**
education.ohio.gov • Steubenville City Schools + statewide G3-G5 OST averages.

12 **Washington OSPI Smarter Balanced**
https://washingtonstatereportcard.ospi.k12.wa.us/ • Bellevue / Issaquah / Lake Washington SBA.

13 **Oakland County 115 — MI affluent peer 2025**
https://oaklandcounty115.com/2025/09/14/test-results-show-reading-proficiency-among-third-and-fourth-graders-across-oakland-county/ • G3+G4 ELA 2025 head-to-head.

References (2 of 5) — Curriculum evidence sources

EdReports / Reading League / ESSA / WWC / MDE / Knowledge Matters

14 **EdReports.org curriculum reviews**

https://edreports.org/ • Green/Yellow/Red gateway ratings: Text Quality / Building Knowledge / Foundational Skills / Usability. v2.0 rubric (2024-25) explicitly assesses SoR alignment.

15 **The Reading League — Curriculum Navigation Reports**

https://www.thereadingleague.org/curriculum-navigation-reports/ • SoR-only evaluation: "red flag practices" (three-cueing, leveled-text decoding, lack of phoneme-grapheme systematicity).

16 **Evidence for ESSA**

https://www.evidenceforessa.org/ • ESSA tiers (Strong, Moderate, Promising, Rationale) for K-5 ELA programs. Used for 95 Phonics (ESSA Strong), IMSE OG+ (Promising), etc.

17 **What Works Clearinghouse / IES**

https://ies.ed.gov/ncee/wwc/ • Federal evidence registry. Reviewed Orton-Gillingham-based interventions; found insufficient qualifying studies.

18 **Michigan MDE Section 35m Tier-1 list**

https://www.michigan.gov/mde/services/academic-standards/literacy/literacy-grants/section-35m • State-approved K-5 evidence-based ELA curricula (Dec 2025 release).

19 **Knowledge Matters Campaign**

https://knowledgematterscampaign.org/ • Recognized knowledge-building K-5 ELA programs: CKLA, EL Education, Wit & Wisdom, ARC Core, Bookworms, Fishtank.

References (3 of 5) — Science of Reading research & journalism

Independent scholarly + investigative sources cited in mechanism slide and curriculum evaluation

20 **Emily Hanford / APM Reports**

"Sold a Story" podcast series + investigations. https://features.apmreports.org/sold-a-story/ • Documented Calkins UoS / F&P / Reading Recovery critiques.

21 **APM Reports — EdReports & SoR (March 2025)**

https://www.apmreports.org/story/2025/03/06/edreports-reading-curriculum-reviews-science-of-reading • Investigation of EdReports all-green ratings on basal programs (Wonders, myView, Into Reading).

22 **Natalie Wexler — The Knowledge Gap**

Avery (2019). https://nataliewexler.com/the-knowledge-gap/ • Framework that comprehension depends on background knowledge built via coherent content sequence.

23 **Tim Shanahan — Shanahan on Literacy**

https://www.shanahanonliteracy.com/ • Reading research and instructional practice. Strategy instruction critique cited in mechanism slide.

24 **Mark Seidenberg — Language at the Speed of Sight**

Basic Books (2017). https://seidenbergreading.net/ • Cognitive science of reading; critique of balanced literacy.

25 **Lane et al. (2025) — UFLI Foundations RRQ study**

Reading Research Quarterly. https://ila.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1002/rrq.607 • ES > 1.0 SD on early-literacy outcomes; districtwide Florida pilot.

26 **Karin Chenoweth — Districts That Succeed**

Harvard Education Press (2021) • Sustained-outperformer district case studies (Steubenville, Seaford, Lane OK, etc.).

27 **Success for All Foundation — Steubenville case study**

https://www.successforall.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/CS_Steubenville-1.pdf • 25-year SFA implementation; 93-100% G3 reading proficient.

28 **The 74 Million — Steubenville coverage**

https://www.the74million.org/article/why-steubenville-ohio-might-be-the-best-school-district-in-america/ • Independent journalism on Steubenville.

29 **Karen Vaites — Southern Surge analysis**

https://www.karenvaites.org/p/the-southern-surge-understanding • Mississippi / Louisiana / Tennessee NAEP gains tied to SoR adoption.

References (4 of 5) — District case-study sources

Specific districts cited in the deck: adoption + outcomes

30 **Kentucky Teacher — Marion County coverage (May 2026)**
https://www.kentuckyteacher.org/news/2026/05/kentucky-ranks-among-nations-best-for-student-recovery-5th-in-reading-8th-in-mathematics/

31 **Kentucky Reading Academies / Lexia LETRS**
https://www.lexialearning.com/kentucky-letrs • https://www.education.ky.gov/curriculum/EarlyLiteracy/Pages/ky_reading_Academies.aspx

32 **Education Scorecard PDFs — case studies**
Marion County: https://educationscorecard.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/05/KY_Marion-County_Case-Study.pdf • 20 DOTR district PDFs in /research/escorecard_pdfs/

33 **Fond du Lac SD — Strategic Plan + Studer Education**
https://www.fonddulac.k12.wi.us/page/strategic-plan • Aug 2022 strategic plan; CKLA + Amplify ELA + Bridges + TCI + Mystery Science stack.

34 **UVA-PLE / Darden Partnership for Leaders in Education**
https://www.darden.virginia.edu/uva-ple/ • Leadership and instructional-redesign partnership underlying Fond du Lac's turnaround.

35 **Palo Alto USD — Every Student Reads Initiative (ESRI)**
https://www.pausd.org/learning/esri • Exited Calkins UoS 2021; mandatory Orton-Gillingham K-3 training.

36 **Spring Branch ISD — Texas STR framework**
https://www.springbranchisd.com/studentsfamilies/literacy • TX Science of Teaching Reading state mandate.

37 **West Baton Rouge / LA DOE Wit & Wisdom adoption**
https://doe.louisiana.gov/docs/default-source/curricular-resources/great-minds-pbc---wit-wisdom-with-fundations-and-geodes-ela-grades-k-3-(-2023).pdf

38 **WI Act 20 / Wisconsin Reads**
https://dpi.wi.gov/wi-reads/curriculum • State science-of-reading mandate (2023) with approved curriculum list.

39 **Tennessee Department of Education — Reading 360 + HQIM mandate**
https://www.tn.gov/education/reading-360.html • State SoR PD (60 hours) + approved K-5 curriculum list.

40 **EdWeek — "Inside the Long Beach Way" (2007)**
https://www.edweek.org/leadership/inside-the-long-beach-way/2007/09 • Carl Cohn era Open Court tradition documented.

41 **Amplify — Aldine ISD CKLA adoption (Jul 2020)**
https://amplify.com/news/aldine-isd-adopts-amplifys-integrated-early-literacy-suite-supports-students-in-learning-to-read-confidently-by-third-grade/

42 **Detroit DPSCD + EL Education — Skillman Foundation grant**
https://www.skillman.org/blog/standardswork-receives-grant-to-support-implementation-of-transformative-literacy-curriculum-in-detroit-public-schools/ • https://www.detroitk12.org/academics/core-curriculum/english-language-arts-and-literacy

43 **NYC Reads — Chalkbeat / EdWeek / K-12 Dive**
Chalkbeat: https://www.chalkbeat.org/newyork/2025/07/07/nyc-reads-solves-screener-data-eric-adams-school-curriculum-mandate/ • EdWeek: Phase 1 vs Phase 2 confidence data (Jul 2025).

References (5 of 5) — Project artifacts + how to verify

Every claim is reproducible from the public GitHub repository

github.com/akarpo/tsd-k5ela-choice

Web presentation

`README.md`	Project README + slide map
`index.html`	Vanilla-JS slide viewer
`slides/*.png`	28 rendered slide PNGs (144 DPI)
`deck/Troy_K5_ELA_Executive_Summary.pptx`	Source PowerPoint deck

Reproducibility pipeline

`analysis/extract_seda_subset.py`	SEDA 2025.1 → 50-district subset
`analysis/compute_deltas.py`	Pre/post-COVID Δ matrix
`analysis/build_deck.py`	Builds the .pptx deck
`docs/REPRODUCIBILITY.md`	How to reproduce in 3 commands
`docs/METHODOLOGY.md`	Metrics, time windows, district universe
`docs/DISTRICT_UNIVERSE.md`	All 50 districts with NCES LEA IDs

Processed data (data/)

`seda_2025_pooled.json`	SEDA cs G3-G5 pooled by year × subgroup
`seda_2025_state.json`	State-level SEDA averages by year
`seda_subgroup_delta.csv`	Pre/post-COVID Δ per subgroup × district
`master_dataset.csv`	2,544 rows: dist × year × grade × subgroup
`seda_2009_2025_extract.csv`	Raw SEDA 2025.1 extract (50 dists × G3-G5)
`troy_swd_ela.csv`	Troy SWD M-STEP %prof, G3-G5 2015-25

Supporting reports (reports/)

`synthesis.md`	Master synthesis report
`quantitative_analysis.md`	28-district state-test analysis
`education_scorecard_2026_dotr.md`	20 DOTR outperformer case studies
`curriculum_evaluations.md`	14 Section 35m curricula evaluated
`collab_lit_ufli_pressure_test.md`	Collab Lit + UFLI critique